been home to many major and minor faiths and intense sociopolitical contestation. Although it is often seen as a centre of Hindu orthodoxy, it has a rich, pluralistic past and is equally the city of Kabir and Ravidas. In a city that relies on the business of pilgrimage and death, I look at two of its core communities that operate along the Ganga: the Mallah boatmen and the Dom workers on the cremation ghats.

I see this book as my ongoing conversation with these sites and travellers. It began fifteen years ago and a snapshot of it is frozen in these pages. Over time I may well revise some of my opinions; regret that I forgot to say some things, or didn't say them well enough; and at times be surprised at how well I articulated my view. This book will also continue to remind me that all my immersion in lost worlds is largely to better understand my own.

Gurgaon, January 2020